

1.4.3.5 Dribbling

Basic guidelines for dribbling

The player dribbling with the ball must keep it at a suitable distance to enable them to beat the defender.

They must also be perfectly balanced, and can use feints to throw the opponent off balance.

Beating a player from a standing start or when already moving

Beating a player from a standing start hinges on the forward's ability to wrong-foot the defender and get past them at the right moment. Conversely, beating a player from a running start hinges on being able to accelerate rapidly.

The first part of the run

The player with the ball who wants to dribble past a defender must first run directly at them, trying to do so at the fastest possible speed. This means they must get close to the defender with the ball before taking them on with a combination of feinting and dribbling.

Why is it important to take the defender on?

This denies the defender the time to force the forward towards the area of the court that is 'defender-friendly'. In addition, when the player with the ball runs straight at their opponent, the defender is left off guard and their legs and upper body are not at the ideal angle to execute a defensive action and successfully thwart the forward.

Feints and intended movements

A feint is executed by a player just before they try to get past their opponent. Basically, this involves the player on the ball making the opposition player think they have opted for one way of getting past them before finally making the intended movement.

A successful feint wrong-foots the defender, enabling the forward to beat their man.

Timing the feint and the intended movement right

When dribbling past an opponent, a player has to make them think the feint is actually the real move. Therefore, players must not 'sell' a feint too quickly (the defender might not realise what is happening and therefore not react at all), or too slowly as this might give the defender enough time to regain their balance and counter the attack. The 'real' move must

be executed very quickly to ensure the defender does not have a chance to recover their balance.

Where to get past the opponent

The forward with the ball must attack the defender on the side where they have their leading foot (e.g. to the right of a defender who is leading with the right foot, considered the 'weak side'). The best moment to go past the opponent is when the leading foot is just about to touch the ground.

Dribbling in order to develop a move

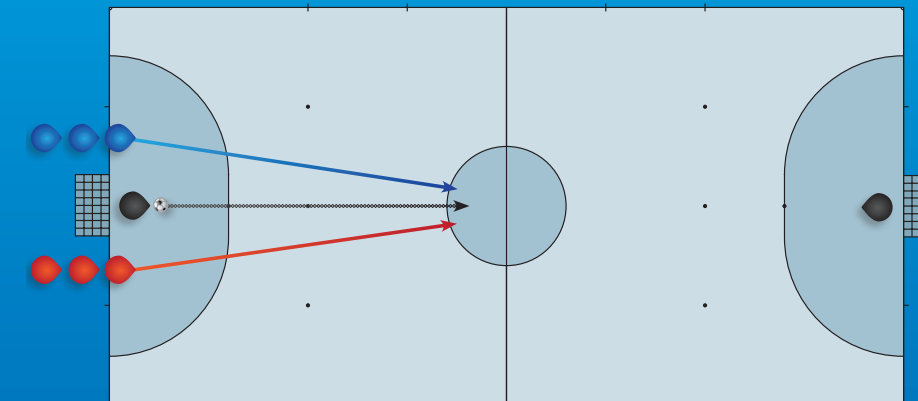
When a team is looking to attack they must concentrate on passing rather than dribbling. Players should only take opponents on in 'safe' parts of the court when their team-mates are in the right position. Dribbling is key to creating situations that give the attacking team a numerical advantage over their opponents and to occupying space in attack, as it helps create shooting opportunities, open up dangerous passing angles and prevent the opposition from pressing.

Coaching methods designed to improve ability in taking on opponents

- Beating an opponent whose movement is limited (positioning in lines).
- Beating an opponent who has more room to move (restricted to a zone).
- Beating an opponent in an unrestricted space.
- Improving perception of space and time in one-on-one situations: drills in which the defender and forward start moving at different times, either when the forward already has the ball (e.g. where the defender sets off first, the attacker goes first, or both set off at the same time, from a stationary start, etc.) or when the forward receives the ball from a team-mate before dribbling.

Dribbling drills

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DRILL DESCRIPTION

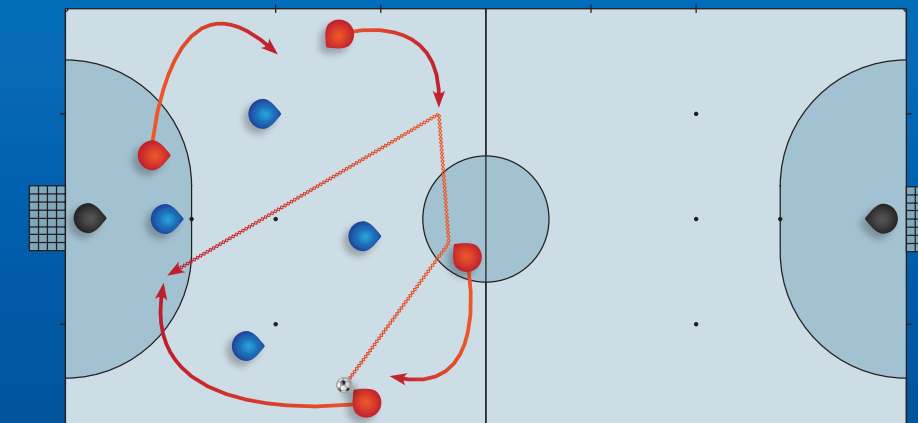
1v1 dribbling. The goalkeeper kicks the ball towards the centre of the court to two players who simultaneously run from beside the posts. Whoever gets to the ball first is the attacker, and the other is the defender. The attacker attempts to dribble past the defender and have a shot at goal.

VARIATIONS

The attackers start from a sitting position, or lying on their front or back, etc.

The drill can also be carried out in both goals, at the same time, with another goalkeeper and two other groups of players.

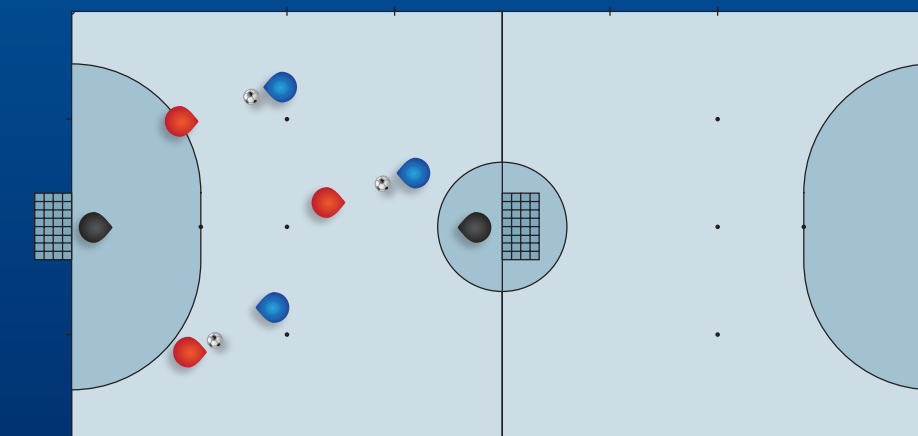
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DRILL DESCRIPTION

A game of 2v2 plus goalkeepers takes place on half a court. The playing area is divided into two zones by an imaginary line running between the centre of the two goals. One attacker and one defender play in each zone. The players may not leave their respective zones, although the ball can be passed from one zone to the other.

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DRILL DESCRIPTION

Three pairs of players plus goalkeepers line up on half a court, in 1v1 situations. Each pair has a ball.